

Recency Bias

What is it?

The tendency to remember recent events much more strongly than older ones.

History

Identified within the broader work on memory recall and cognitive biases in the 1960s research on serial-position effects.

The Psychology Behind It

People assign heavier weight to the most recent experience when forming opinions or making future decisions. A single recent negative event can override several older positive experiences, impacting brand trust and decision-making.

Why It Matters

- Reduced loyalty
- Lower referrals
- Negative reviews
- Engagement drop

How to Apply It

- Prioritize recent touchpoints (sort by latest)
- Create smooth endings (pleasant last interactions)
- Respond fast to recent issues
- Highlight fresh activity and status

Theory in Action

Amazon protects the user experience by offering fast and easy returns, helping recover negative recency moments.

Airbnb follows up after stays, making the final interaction carefully crafted and positive.

Final Thought

People judge based on what just happened — not the full journey.

Make the last experience consistently positive, and customers will remember you better.